PLAN

12-Month Ironman Roadmap

Week 1 starts Monday 5 October 2026. Week 52 ends Sunday 3 October 2027. Assumed race: Sunday 3 October 2027.

Athlete profile the plan is built around

Swim: sustained 2:00/100 m, pool all year, open water late May to early October. Bike: road bike plus indoor trainer, power on both. Run: treadmill only until weight-loss goals are met, history of Achilles and knee pain, so running volume is gated by how the joints feel, never by the calendar. Start weight 207 lb. Strength and prehab are non-negotiable parts of the week.

Monthly progression

Month	Weeks	Phase	What changes	Hours / week
1. October 2026	1-4	Foundation	Establish the weekly rhythm. Baseline tests: 20-min bike FTP test, 400 m swim time trial. Swim = body position and catch drills. Bike = Zone 2 with cadence work. Run = walk/run intervals on the treadmill, 2x per week. Strength 2x per week with Achilles and knee prehab.	5.5 - 6.5
2. November 2026	5-9	Base 1	Third swim added. Trainer rides stay Zone 2, cadence and single-leg work. Walk/run moves toward 3 min run / 2 min walk. Strength 2x per week, loads rise slowly.	6.5 - 7.5
3. December 2026	10-13	Base 2	Swim endurance sets around Critical Swim Speed (CSS). First sweet-spot intervals (88-93% FTP) on the trainer. Run intervals to 5 min run / 1 min walk. Keep the recovery week honest over the holidays.	7 - 8
4. January 2027	14-17	Base 3	Re-test FTP and CSS. Sweet-spot 2 x 15 min. Longest trainer ride reaches 2 h. Run: 20-25 min continuous if joints are quiet. Strength moves to heavier, lower-rep work.	8 - 9
5. February 2027	18-21	Base 4	Swim sessions reach 2.0-2.5 km. Long trainer ride 2.5 h. Run 30 min continuous, 3x per week only if pain-free. Introduce short brick (bike then 10 min run).	8.5 - 9.5
6. March 2027	22-26	Build 1	Bike threshold intervals. Swim 2.5-3 km with race-pace 100s. Run 40 min long run using run/walk. Weekly brick. Re-test at end of block.	9 - 10
7. April 2027	27-30	Build 2	Outdoor riding resumes. Long ride 3 h with aero position time. Run long 50 min. Open-water skills rehearsed in the pool (sighting, drafting, deck-ups).	10 - 11
8. May 2027	31-35	Build 3	Open water begins late May. Long ride 3.5-4 h with race-pace blocks. Long run 60-70 min. Half-distance rehearsal at month end: 1.9 km swim, 90 km ride, 10 km run/walk.	11 - 12
9. June 2027	36-39	Ironman Specific 1	Weekly open-water swim. Long ride 4-4.5 h with fuelling practice (60-90 g carbs/h). Long run 75-90 min run/walk. Race-day nutrition locked in.	12 - 13
10. July 2027	40-43	Ironman Specific 2	Optional 70.3 race mid-July as a dress rehearsal. Long ride 5 h. Long run 100 min. Swim 3.8 km continuous in open water.	13 - 14
11. August 2027	44-48	Peak	Longest ride 5.5-6 h plus 30 min run off the bike. Long run 2-2.5 h run/walk. Peak week around 15 h, then a full recovery week.	13 - 15

Month	Weeks	Phase	What changes	Hours / week
12. September 2027	49-52	Taper and Race	Volume drops 30%, 50%, then 70% while short race-pace touches remain. Race week: travel, bike check, course swim, race on Sunday 3 October 2027 (assumed; adjust to your actual event).	10 down to 5

Rules that never change

• Every month follows build-build-build-recover (5-week months add one more build week). Recovery weeks cut volume by 35-40% and are where adaptation happens.
• Run progression: increase weekly run minutes by no more than 10%. Pain above 3/10 during a run, or stiffness the next morning that lasts past the first 10 minutes, means repeat the previous week. Two repeats in a row means drop back one week and add a prehab session.
• Treadmill at 1% incline, run/walk from day one. Continuous running only arrives when a full month of intervals has been pain-free.
• Bike zones come from a 20-minute FTP test (FTP = 95% of the 20-min average power). Re-test in Months 4, 7 and 10.
• Swim pace comes from a 400 m time trial (Month 1) and a CSS test (400 m + 200 m) from Month 3 on. Re-test every 8 weeks.
• One full rest day per week (Monday is strength-only, no cardio). Sleep and body-weight trend are reviewed at each month boundary; the plan is adjusted before the next month is written.
• Strength never goes to failure. It is there to make tendons and knees robust, not to build a physique.

Training zones reference

Zone	Bike (% FTP)	Run / Swim feel	Talk test
Z1 Recovery	under 55%	Very easy, walking-pace effort	Full sentences easily
Z2 Endurance	56-75%	All-day pace. Most of the year lives here	Full sentences
Z3 Tempo	76-90%	Comfortably hard, 70.3 race effort	Short sentences
Z4 Threshold	91-105%	Hard, 40-60 min race effort. CSS pace in the pool	A few words
Z5 VO2	106-120%	Very hard, 3-8 min efforts (rare in this plan)	No talking

Folder structure

Each month folder holds a Month Overview PDF plus four activity folders (Swim, Bike, Run, Strength). Each activity folder has one folder per week, and each week folder holds a single printable PDF with every session of that activity for the week. The Swim PDFs include cue cards for the drills used that week, so the sheet is all you need at the pool. Google Calendar events point back to the matching PDF.